How We Talk in South Boston

By David Lindsay-Abaire

INTRODUCTION

Hate in America is a dreadful, daily constant. The dragging death of a black man in Jasper, Texas; the crucifixion of a gay man in Laramie, Wyo.; and post-9.11 hate crimes against hundreds of Arab Americans, Muslim Americans and Sikhs are not "isolated incidents." They are eruptions of a nation's intolerance. Bias is a human condition, and American history is rife with prejudice against groups and individuals because of their race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or other differences. The issue is not a comic one; however, sometimes over-the-top comedy can spotlight the issues even more effectively than a serious approach. May I present David Lindsay-Abaire's How We Talk in South Boston . . . . a comic look at an extremely serious issue where everyone faces some degree of intolerance.

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(Lights up on a living room [parlor) in a blue-collar home in South Boston. MARY *is making a latch-hook rug when her husband* NORMAN *enters with a car door. His arm is lodged inside it.)*

NORMAN: Muthah-ra-Gawd, look at dis. My ahm's cot in da kah dewah.

MARY: Doan bring dat hunka gahbitch into my pahlah, Naw man. Take it back outside and diddle inda gudda.

NORMAN: I ain't diddlin'. My ahm's cot.

MARY: Get owda heah. Ya ahm's cot? *(Calls downstairs.)* Hey, Mahdy, ya fathah's ahm's cot in the kah dewah. Cawl da fiah depahtmend. Tell 'em to get ovah heah befoah he gets dubbaya dee-faddy on my latch-hook rug.

NORMAN: Dat's a nice rug yuh makin'.

MARY: Yuh like it? Thea havin' a time down at the VFW Post in Mahch, a bazah, like an ahts and craffs faih, an I dought I could sell my rugs.

NORMAN: Dat's a great idear, Meery. (MARTY *enters).*

MARTY: Yuh cawlin' me?

MARY: Yeah, wheah da frig whiryah?

MARTY: I coodin' heah ya. I was downsteahs ina cella.

MARY: Dis frickin' chowdah-head got his ahm cot in da kah dewah.

MARTY: How'd he get his ahm cot in the kah dewah?

NORMAN: I was fixin' da windah 'cause it was hahd to open, so I took da dewah apaht and was fiddlin' aroun' and my ahm got cot.

MARTY: Dat's wicket pissa. Whadda looza.

NORMAN: Get me owda heah. I gotta watch da Sox at fowah.

MARTY: I bet yaw cot in duh lockin' mechanism. I'll go get yaw kah keez.

(MARTY *exits.)*

NORMAN: D'jew buy me some beah, Meery? You know Hahvey and Kevin McCahthy ah comin' ova to watch da game.

MARY: Sully's not comin'?

NORMAN: Nah, Sully went to da dawg track with Fitzy an Beah-zo.

MARY: Okay. I went to Stah Mahket on Sadaday inny-ways. I bought beah and a pahty platta foah yis. I can cook up some budded con on da cob. An' I got some sub rolls so you can make spuckies.

NORMAN: D'jew get any tawnic? Cause Hahvey don't drink no mowah.

MARY: Yeah. I got two big bosses a' Pepsi. The three-leetah kind. And a box of hoodsies foah afta.

NORMAN: Aw, we should still have hoodsies left ova from lass Saint Paddy's Day.

MARY: Dose was hahd and freeza burnt. I trew ' em in cia barrel. I didn't get no jimmies dough. You want me to run upta Brigham's?

(BARBARA, *their daughter, enters.)*

BARBARA: Ma, Dad, I have some wicket good news.

MARY: Bahbra. Ya fathah's ahm's cot in a kah dewah.

BARBARA: Whadda looza! Wanna heah my good news now? (MARTY *enters.)*

MARTY: I gut da kah keez. *(Holds up car keys.)*

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BARBARA: Ma, Dad, Mahty, I'm gettin' married!

MARY: Oh my gawd, my dodda's gettin' meerried!

NORMAN: You know I got a bum ticka! I'm havin' a hahd attack heah! Gimme a hug! *(Hugs her, but the car door makes it awkward.)*

BARBARA: Ahhh! Ya hit me wit da kah dewah, ya looza!

NORMAN: Sorry.

MARY: Wait a minute, Bahbra, who ah ya marion?

BARBARA: His name is Mahlin.

NORMAN: We don't know no Mahlins.

MARY: Shuwah we do. Mahlin Perkins. Da animal guy.

NORMAN: How come we neva herda dis Mahlin ya marion?

BARBARA: 'Cause I was afraid ya wooden likem.

NORMAN: Why wooden we likem?

BARBARA: He likes da Yankees. *(There's a long, uncomfortable pause.)*

MARTY: Yalove 'em, Bahb?

BARBARA: Moah than my haht can beah.

MARTY: Den I ken accep' 'em, liddle sista.

BARBARA: Danks, Mahty. Ma?

MARY: I neva liked baseball. I do an kayah.

BARBARA: Dad? (NORMAN *spits in her face.)* Ya spit in my eye, ya looza!

NORMAN: You know about da curse, Bahb?

BARBARA: Yeah, but ya ain't gotta spit at me.

NORMAN: In nine-teen nine-teen, Babe Root was a Red Sox playah, an den Harry Frazee solt 'em to da Yankees, and da rest is history. Eva since den, my team has been cursed. In eighdy yeahs, we hahven won a Whirl Series. Shuwah, deer ah udda teams wit worse reckids, but nobiddy loses in such haht-breakin' ways. An' above all da teams in da leagues, da Yankees have

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been ah ahch enemies. Damn dat Harry Frazee. And damn all dose Yankees. Fenway Pahk shoulda been da house dat Root built. And now my ony dodda is gonna tell me she's marion a Yankee fan?

BARBARA: But I love' em.

MARY: Da haht is a mysterious oahgan, Nawman. Dat I know.

NORMAN: SO doan I! I know dat too, Meery!

BARBARA: Please, Daddy. . .

NORMAN: Awww, jeez. Alright. But nobiddy mention dat dis kid's a Yankee fan. Especially to Kevin McCahthy.

BARBARA: Oh dank you, Daddy! *(Hugs him, but the car door gets in the way.)* Ahhhh, dat dawn kah dewah!

MARTY: I gut da kah keez! *(Tries to unlock the car door.)*

MARLON: *(Offstage.)* Knock-knock. Anyone home?

BARBARA: In heah, honey! Dat's MaWin. He was pahkin' da kah. Everyone be nice.

(MARLON *enters. He's a black man.)*

MARLON: Hello. I'm Marlon. I was parking the car by the bar on the far corner.

BARBARA: Dozen he tock funny?*(They just stare at him blankly.)* I just tolt 'em you was a Yankee fan.

MARLON: Oh, yeah? Sorry, I hope you don't hold it against me. Least I'm not a Mets fan. I was rooting for you guys in '86. Too bad about that Billy Buckner thing. Gimpy little ground ball down the first-base line. Right between Buckner's feet. World Series riding on that simple grounder. You must've been angry as heck. Kinda funny, though, right?

MARY: Yoah black. Yourah black man.

MARLON: Yes, I know.

NORMAN: This is a black man, Bahbra.

BARBARA: Isn't he goahjis?

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NORMAN: A black man who likes da Yankees and tinks Bucknuh is funny. *(Spits in MARLON's Face.)*

MARLON: Eww. He spit at me.

MARY: Calm ya livva, Nawman.

NORMAN: Mahty, goto da stowah and get me a regulah coffee.

MARY: Anna cahtin a milk. Deah's money in my pockabook.

MARTY: I wanna stay.

NORMAN: We gotta talk to ya sistah.

MARTY: I'm gay. Since youah so mad anyways and spittin' on evrybidy, I might as well tell yuhs.

MARLON: I support you, Marty. Be proud of your feelings.'

NORMAN: Not in dis neighbahood, Take it to da liberals ova da River at Hahvahd. Dale tellya to mahch in da parade ahm in ahm.

BARBARA: Daddy. . .

MARY: He do an mean nuttin' by it. He was mugged by a black guy once.

MARTY: *A gay* black guy?

MARY: Shut up, Mahtty. Ya fathuh's upset.

NORMAN: You kids doe know about history. Dat's ya problem right deah.

BARBARA: I'm marion MaWin whetha yis like it oah not.

NORMAN: Yaw ancestas came ova cuzza da famines in Iyaland in da 1850s. An you tink dose uppity Brahmin wannid 'em heah in Boston? No. Nobidy wannid a buncha imergrents. So we found a liddle slice a land ona watah and made it ahrown. The Irish were discriminated against foh all dose yeahs, an now deah gonna tell us weah racist foah protectin' duh ony place dat's ahrown.

MARLON: I can't understand a word he's saying.

NORMAN: Yuh stay wit yuh own kind. Dat's how God wants it. *(An ASIAN MAN enters.)*

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ASIAN MAN: I couldn't help overhearing the argument. I guess it's okay to come out now.

MARTY: Mom, Dad, this is Ping, my boyfriend. He's been livin' inda basement wit me for tree months.

PING: It's a pleasure to meet you. Arm's caught in the car door, huh?

NORMAN: Whad is goin' on heah? Did I raise yous kids to be freaks? Friggin League a Nations in dis house! Dis ain't Greenwitch Village, Mahty!

MARY: It's dat tollarinse ting they been tocking about on da TV: Duh kids musta been watchin' da TV:

NORMAN: No tollarinse in dis house. Dis is Southie! We doan tolerate nobidy heah! Nobidy! Day all wanna take us ova. Duh fohced buss in' was da first step. Remembuh when Bob Kraft tried to put the Pats Stadium in my backyahd? I don't tink so! We chased his Yiddish butt owda heah! I shoulda known he was no good, trying to move dat Jacksonville game so it wooden conflict wit Yom Kippa, whadeva dat is!

PING: I've never heard someone be so blatantly prejudiced.

BARBARA: Ain't he funny?

NORMAN: I ain't prejudiced!

BARBARA: See what I mean? Daddy, youah hilairy-us!

NORMAN: Don't laugh at me, Bahb!

MARLON: He's almost as funny as Bill Buckner!

NORMAN: Get outta my house!

MARY: You do look funny, Nawman! Ya face all red, ya ahm cot inda kah dewah!

(They're all laughing at him now. He's so angry he can barely speak.)

MARTY: Hey, Dad, live and let live, okay?

MARY: Ah you okay, Nawman?

PING: I'm a doctor. I can help.

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NORMAN: I do an need no help! I'm fine da way I am!

MARLON: Get him to my car. We'll drive him to City Hospital.

NORMAN: I doan need yis help. . . I'm fine widout yis. *(He crawls to the exit, the car door dragging.)*

MARY: Youah bein' very stubbin.

NORMAN: I doan needa tolerate nobidy . . . *(He collapses.)* Ahhhh . . .*(He dies.)*

MARY: Muthah-ra-Gawd, he's dead.

BARBARA: My fathah is dead.

MARY: He wasn't really youah fathah anyways. Kids, I'd like you to meet Frankie Grey Hawk. (FRANKIE *enters, an older man in full Native American regalia.)*

FRANKIE: How. Me smokum peace pipe.

MARY: Isn't he funny? Dat's duh ferse ting he says each mohnin' befoah he sneaks oudda da house. He's sucha joka.

FRANKIE: I'm actually a linguistics professor at Northeastern.

BARBARA: Youah ah fathuh?

MARTY: Dat explains Bahbra's terrible drinkin' problem.

BARBARA: And Mathy's dream to open a gamblin' casino!

FRANKIE: Kids, those are just racial stereotypes perpetuated by the white man to keep us down.

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